

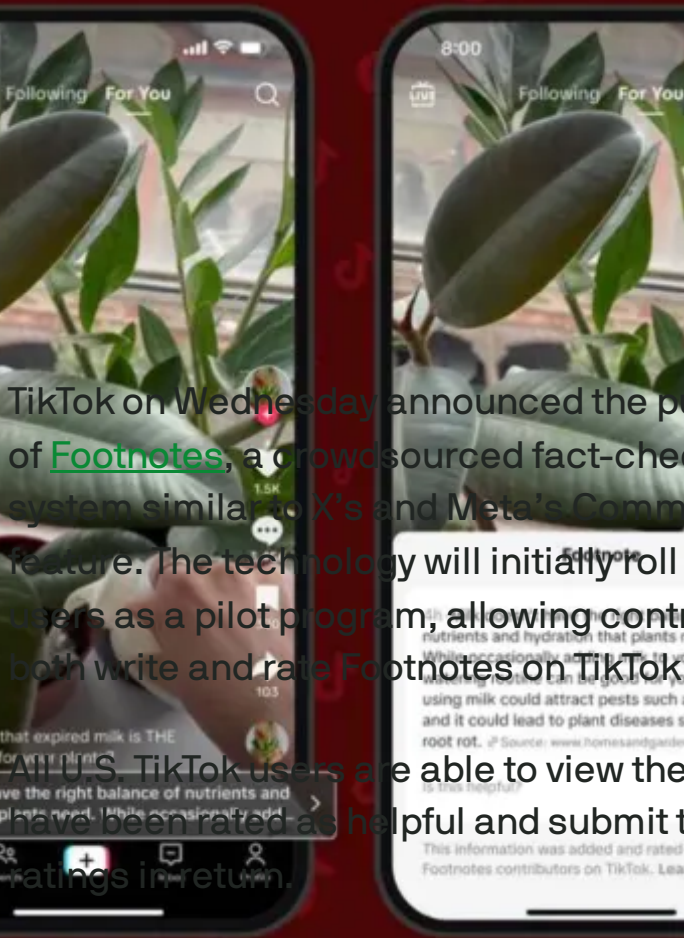
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SOCIAL



Footnotes, TikTok's  
crowdsourced fact-  
checks, launches in the  
US



TikTok on Wednesday announced the public launch of [Footnotes](#), a crowdsourced fact-checking system similar to X's and Meta's Community Notes feature. The technology will initially roll out to U.S. users as a pilot program, allowing contributors to both write and rate Footnotes on TikTok videos.

All U.S. TikTok users are able to view the notes that have been rated as helpful and submit their own ratings in return.

The company first [announced its plans to test Footnotes](#) in April. At the time, it described the feature as a way to give the community more context around TikTok's content.

IMAGE CREDITS: TIKTOK

Like X's Community Notes and other similar programs, TikTok uses a bridging algorithm that tries to find consensus among people who typically have different views. If both sides rate a note as helpful, then it's more likely to be true, according to this method. This also guards against brigading, where one side tries to sway a decision their way by voting similarly.

The company says notes can help people better understand what they're seeing on the platform by adding more information and context. Sometimes the person who posted the video that gets a note is actively trying to misrepresent a situation, while other times they may have simply missed other

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information or updates that could be helpful for viewers.

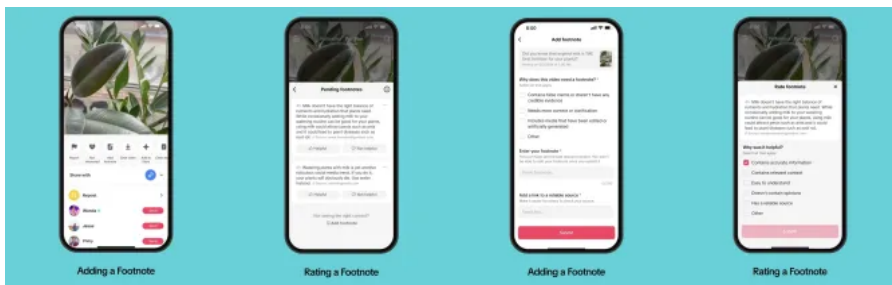


IMAGE CREDITS:TIKTOK

TikTok began allowing U.S. users to [apply](#) to be a contributor back in April, as long as they were at least 18, had been on TikTok for more than six months, and had no recent history of violating TikTok’s Community Standards. Since then, TikTok says nearly 80,000 U.S. users have qualified as Footnotes contributors.

Though new to TikTok, Community Notes-style features have existed for several years.

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Twitter pioneered this idea, originally called Birdwatch, [back in 2020](#). It officially [rolled out the Birdwatch fact-checks the following year](#) and [expanded the program globally in 2022](#). Now called Community Notes, the feature has expanded under Elon Musk's ownership of Twitter/X. More recently, those efforts include allowing [AI to generate notes](#) and new ways to use the system for [highlighting popular content](#) on the platform.

X's [open source](#) Community Notes concept has also inspired similar systems at other social media companies — particularly those looking to appease conservatives who felt that traditional fact-checking systems were biased against them.

In an effort to make amends with the Trump administration and hoping to thwart increased regulation, [Meta dropped fact-checking](#) this year in favor of its [own Community Notes system in the U.S.](#), raising concerns about the [spread of misinformation](#). YouTube is also experimenting with its take on this type of system with its feature called [Notes, which launched last year](#).

However, TikTok says its Footnotes initiative will expand upon its existing Global Fact-checking Program, not replace it.

The company says it continues to work with more than 20 [IFCN](#)-accredited fact-checking organizations, in over 60 languages and in 130 markets around the world.

Topics: [Apps](#) [community notes](#) [fact checking](#)

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Sarah has worked as a reporter for TechCrunch since August 2011. She joined the company after having...

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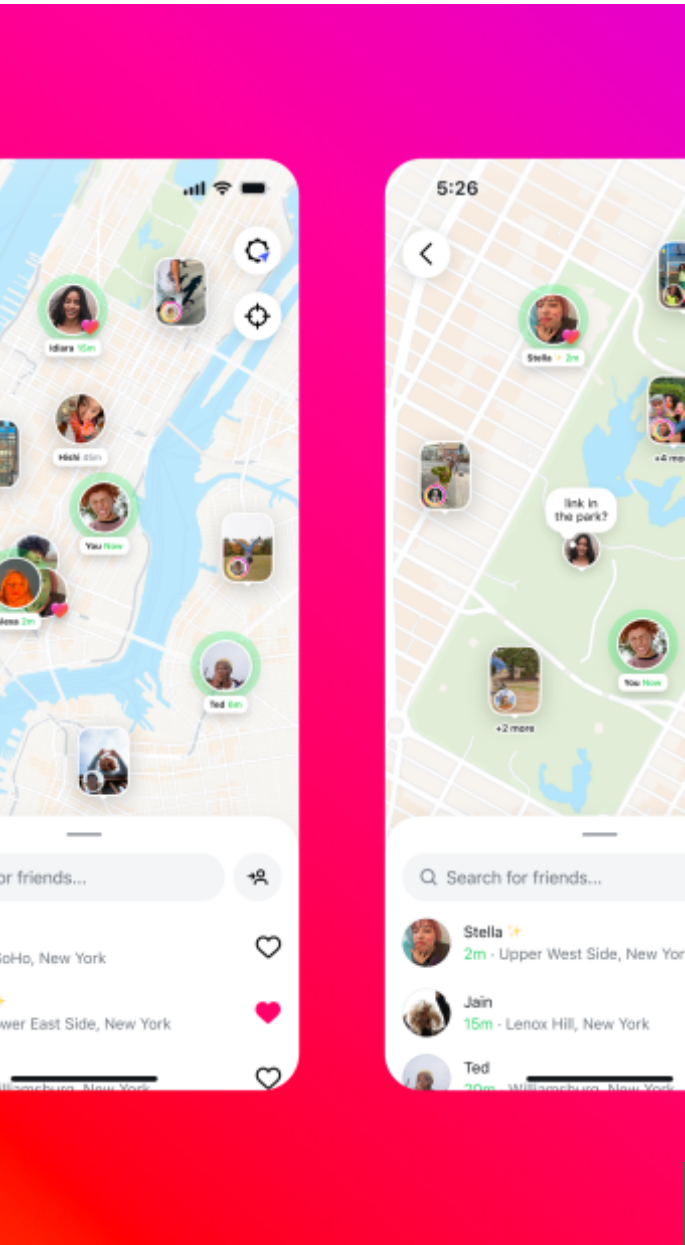


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# Instagram takes on Snapchat with new ‘Instagram Map’

Aisha Malik — 7:00 AM PDT · August 6, 2025

Instagram is rolling out Instagram Map, a new feature that lets users share their most recent active location with others and discover location-based content. The Meta-owned social network is

also launching reposts, and making its “Friends” tab in Reels available globally.

With its new map feature, Instagram is copying yet another popular feature from Snapchat, after cloning the app’s core Stories functionality [back in 2016](#). Instagram is coming for Snap Map’s crown, a feature that recently surpassed 400 million monthly active users and remains one of the app’s core offerings.

Instagram notes that location sharing is off by default on Instagram Map, and a user’s location only updates when they open the app, meaning it doesn’t provide real-time location updates. Snap Map, on the other hand, allows users to choose whether their location is updated only when they open the app or in real time.

It’s worth noting that Instagram does offer [real-time location sharing via DMs](#) (direct messages). However, unlike Apple’s Find My and Snap Map, which let you share your location with others indefinitely, Instagram only lets users do so for up to one hour.

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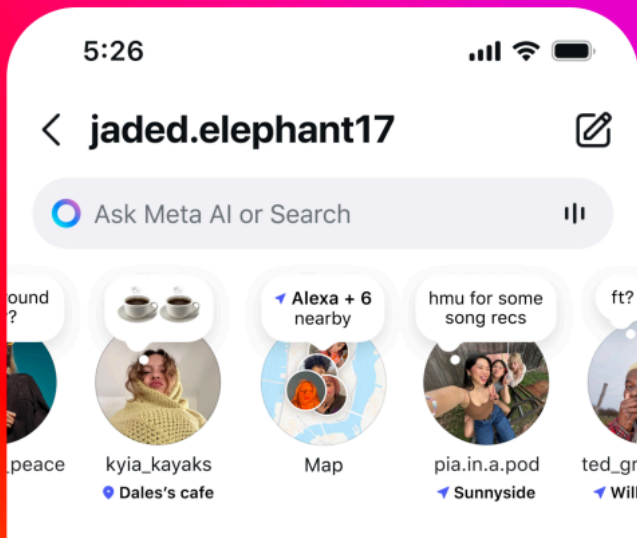
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Regardless of whether you choose to share your location, you can use the map to explore location-based content, Instagram says.

The map also allows users to leave short messages, or [“Notes,”](#) on the map for others to see. Instagram Notes are currently the short messages that appear at the top of your direct messaging feed, but with the launch of Instagram Map, users can now post these short updates on the map.



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Although Instagram is certainly taking on Snapchat with this new feature, it also has the opportunity to appeal to people who were fans of [Zenly](#), a social map app that Snap acquired and then shut down in 2023.

The new map feature is launching in the United States starting Wednesday, with broader global availability coming soon. Users can find the Instagram Map at the top of their DM inbox.

The launch doesn't come as a surprise, as [Instagram was spotted developing](#) the map feature last year.





As for the new “Reposts” feature, Instagram is taking a page out of [TikTok’s book](#) while also creating its own version of the popular “retweet” function from Twitter (now X).

This feature lets Instagram users repost public reels and feed posts. These reposts may show up in their friends’ feeds and will also be displayed in a new “Reposts” tab on their profile. Instagram says the new feature gives users a way to share their interests with others and also offers creators the opportunity to reach a wider audience.

To repost a reel or post, users tap the repost icon. Users can also choose to add a note to the repost by typing into the thought bubble that appears on screen and pressing save.

Regarding the new “Friends” tab in Reels, Instagram launched it in the United States earlier this year and is now making it available globally. The tab lets you see public reels that your friends have liked, commented on, reposted, and created.

For users who want to browse and interact with content privately, Instagram is rolling out the ability to opt out of having content you’ve engaged with shown in the friends tab.

Users can hide their likes, comments, and reposts from the tab. Additionally, they can choose to mute likes, comments, and reposts from specific people they follow.

Topics: [Apps](#) [Instagram](#) [instagram map](#) [Snap Map](#)

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**Aisha Malik**

Consumer News Reporter | [X](#) [Twitter](#) [in](#)

Aisha is a consumer news reporter at TechCrunch. Prior to joining the publication in 2021, she was a telecom reporte...

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# The backlash against Duolingo going 'AI-first' didn't even matter

Amanda Silberling — 8:32 AM PDT · August 7, 2025

IMAGE CREDITS: [DUOLINGO](#)

Duolingo [announced](#) on Wednesday that it beat its quarterly revenue estimates, even though the company faced widespread backlash for choosing

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to embrace generative AI over human workers. Duolingo stock rose [almost 30%](#) on the news.

In April, CEO Luis von Ahn [shared](#) that Duolingo would become an “AI-first” company, phasing out its use of contract workers. He also discouraged teams from hiring more employees, unless the team is unable to automate more of its work. With the use of generative AI, Duolingo introduced 148 new language courses, more than doubling its previous offerings.

“Without AI, it would take us decades to scale our content to more learners,” von Ahn wrote at the time. “We owe it to our learners to get them this content ASAP.”

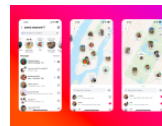
While some Duolingo users have argued that these AI features are making the app worse, the company’s financial metrics tell a different story. Now the company [anticipates](#) making over \$1 billion in revenue this year, and daily active users have grown 40% year-over-year. The growth is significant but falls in the lower range of the company’s estimates of growing between 40% and 45%, which an investor brought up to von Ahn on Wednesday’s quarterly earnings call.

“The reason we came [in] towards the lower end was because I said some stuff about AI, and I didn’t give enough context. Because of that, we got some backlash on social media,” von Ahn said. “The most important thing is we wanted to make the sentiment on our social media positive. We stopped posting edgy posts and started posting things that would get our sentiment more positive. That has worked.”

On TikTok, the top comments on Duolingo’s videos often remain criticisms of the company’s AI approach. Snarky commenters will ask if videos with multiple people in them are made with AI, to

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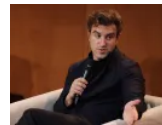
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Aisha Malik - 8 hours ago

## AI



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Sarah Perez - 13 hours ago

## APPS



The backlash against Duolingo going ‘AI-first’ didn’t even matter

Amanda Silberling

- 13 hours ago

which Duolingo will reply, “Nope. Made by our great team!”

But even if public sentiment toward Duolingo has shifted, its bottom line has not ... and from the company’s perspective, that’s what matters.

Topics: [AI](#) [Apps](#) [duolingo](#)



**Amanda Silberling**

Senior Writer |

Amanda Silberling is a senior writer at TechCrunch covering the intersection of technology and culture. She...

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